could be a model for human behavior took root in the work of ethologists in the 1950s and ’60s, such as Konrad Lorenz, Nikolaas Tinbergen, and Karl von Frisch. Studying animals in their natural habitats, they saw how complex the lives of animals were. They began to understand social interactions arising from instinct as well as learned behaviors. The animal studies held a mirror up to human behaviors.

The persistent belief that humans are totally different from other species was firmly rebutted with the advent of gene mapping. When the chimpanzee genome was mapped in 2005—followed by the other great apes—and compared with the human genome, the results were clear. Humans share 98.8 percent of their DNA with chimps, 98.4 percent with gorillas, and 97 percent with orangutans. Humans and great apes are more alike than they are different. Yet it is worth noting that these percentages are based on genes that instruct the body how to make proteins, which make up a very small part of the human genome (about 2 percent). It is likely that the things that make humans different from chimpanzees can be found in the regions of DNA called “junk DNA” because they were previously thought to be redundant. It is now understood that this junk DNA holds vital information about how and when genes are expressed. Still, the similarities between the DNA of humans and the great apes are striking.

“We admit that we are like apes, but we seldom realize that we are apes.”

Richard Dawkins

British evolutionary biologist

Meat-eating hunters

During her studies, Goodall also witnessed chimps eating meat and hunting. As with tool-making, the idea that chimpanzees were carnivorous predators went against all received knowledge. At first, scientists claimed it was aberrant behavior, but as the research continued and more sightings were